

Episode 30: Once Upon a Time... (22) *Saint Seiya* Part 9 – Theatrical *Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth* – Storyboard Art and Meeting Legend

I recently bought a big TV. A 37-inch full-spec high-definition LCD. The "Kameyama Model (亀山モデル)" they call it. Watching MLB broadcasts, binge-watching foreign dramas on cable TV, watching movies on DVD. Man, I'd been wanting something like this for so long (laughs).

Relaxing on a spacious sofa. This sofa is especially good for watching movies. It's like a "mini movie theatres" feeling.

Ah, I haven't watched anime yet (bitter laugh).

Since anime production sites are transitioning to HD-compatible format screen creation, I'm thinking of carefully watching various programmes, focusing on new fall shows, this October.

But well, my biggest favourite is definitely PS2's "Katamari Damacy (塊魂)" (laughs). My wife and I are both fighting the big screen while getting somewhat motion sick from all the spinning. The Xbox 360 version releases this month too. Looking forward to it! (laughs)

Well then.

Resuming long-neglected *Saint Seiya* stories (laughs).

After spring vacation 1988's theatrical "*Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth*" ended, until summer vacation August 1988's theatrical "*Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth*" was about 4 months.

Even already starting storyboard work, making a 70-minute movie was a somewhat (quite?) tight schedule. But well, the director and we staff had firmly grasped something like confidence from *The Heated Battle of the Gods*, so mood-wise we were fully motivated.

"Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth" was located on the 2nd floor of Oizumi Studio's new building. The newest wing at that time of Oizumi Studio, which consisted of patchwork additions, was the "new building" - the 1st floor had "collaborative work" staff rooms, and the 2nd floor had several staff rooms for video works like *Shonan Bakusozoku* (湘南爆走族) and *Crying Freeman*. Our **"Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth"** was also tucked into one of those small spaces (incidentally, that area on the 2nd floor of the new building is now photography rooms and the colour design room where I am).

In the staff room, Director Yamauchi (山内) sat firmly in the very back, with the assistant director's seat next to him. Back-to-back was production progress A-san's (female) seat. Plus about two spare seats. Just a small room like that. Animation Director Araki (荒木) worked at Araki Pro (荒木プロ), so no seat in the staff room. Art and I each worked at our own seats within the studio, so no seats in the staff room.

Director Yamauchi did storyboard work at home on days off, but otherwise was always in the staff room doing storyboard work and various checks. So I remember spending quite a lot of time hanging around that staff room until things got busy. Somehow, being in that room was fun.

One day, after an animation meeting ended, the director and Araki-san came in, and Araki-san was looking at the half-written storyboard on the director's desk. One comment: "All the drawings look like Yamauchi-kun."

"Eh? That's not true. Look, it's properly Seiya (星矢), right?" said the director. "No, no..." Pointing to the director's drawings, Araki-san said, "Look, the face humans see most is their own face in the mirror. So when drawing, it inevitably resembles yourself most." Come to think of it, the storyboard characters Director Yamauchi drew certainly had

faces and body types like Director Yamauchi... "Oh, I see!" everyone nodded deeply. Only the director seemed unconvinced (laughs).

So, eventually the storyboards finished and total cuts were determined, leading to full-length art and colour direction meetings. This time Kubota-san (窪田) only handled art design and art boards, with Uchikawa-shi (内川) as art director. Since Uchikawa Fumihito (内川 文広) wasn't very familiar with *Saint Seiya*, thorough meetings were inevitable.

Meetings were held in the conference room called "Video Room" diagonally across from the staff room. Start time: 11 AM. Full of energy, let's start.

The main story's introduction was an important atmosphere-building scene for this work. The director drew explanation drawings on correction paper used as memo paper while giving detailed explanations for each cut. The clock hands easily passed noon, reaching lunch break. But the meeting was just getting into its groove. Everyone tacitly agreed to skip lunch and continue the meeting.

Eventually the content reached Seiya and friends charging into the Sanctuary, beginning battles with Abel (アベル)'s subordinate Saints. The series of "technique" cuts combined animation, art, colour direction, and photography techniques and ideas. First the director would explain images in his head, then art and I would propose "How about doing it like this?" with discussions of specific methods and necessary mask specifications, etc. As ideas came together and cut images expanded, meeting time naturally expanded too.

The clock hands advanced further, the 3 PM break chime rang, then evening work-end chimes... The scenery outside gradually shifted to night. The meeting continued endlessly with only 2-3 bathroom breaks and no meals. Moreover, content-wise we'd only reached the point where Seiya finally arrived at Abel's temple (laughs).

The full meeting finally ended just before 9 PM. A truly non-stop meeting lasting about 9 hours. Though I'd prepared somewhat for a theatrical work meeting, I never expected it to be this long. But everyone maintained concentration through to the end - amazing. Well, honestly, after finishing, both I and the two art people had fatigue pour out all at once (bitter laugh).

"Huh? We ended up skipping meals," said the director. "If you'd said something, we could have had dinner breaks - nobody spoke up."

From beginning to end, only Director Yamauchi remained consistently upbeat and energetic at his own pace.

(07.10.02)